9 DEVOTIONALS ON SECOND TIMOTHY

Faithful to the End

Dr. Johannes (Hannes) A. Nortjé

How to use this booklet

1. Set aside about 15 to 20 minutes for each day, ideally somewhere quiet.
2. Read the Scripture passage first, slowly – aloud, if you can. It stands at the start of each devotional.
3. "Digging Deeper" takes you into the context and the language of the original text. "Living It Out" asks what it means for you.
4. Take your time with the questions. You may want to write your answers down.
5. Close with the prayer – and with your own words.

Faithful to the End
9 devotionals on Second Timothy

Scripture: own translation from the Greek by Dr. Johannes A. Nortjé. Base text: SBL Greek New Testament, © 2010 Society of Biblical Literature and Logos Bible Software (CC BY 4.0).

© 2026 Dr. Johannes A. Nortjé · CC BY-NC-ND 4.0

Read online: https://hannesnortje.github.io/devotionals/2tim/en/

Contents

Day 1	Rekindle the Gift of God 2 Timothy 1:1–7
Day 2	Do Not Be Ashamed of the Testimony 2 Timothy 1:8–18
Day 3	Strengthened by Grace: Soldier, Athlete and Farmer 2 Timothy 2:1–7
Day 4	The Word of God Is Not Chained 2 Timothy 2:8–13
Day 5	An Approved Worker and a Vessel for Honour 2 Timothy 2:14–26
Day 6	Difficult Times and a Show of Godliness 2 Timothy 3:1–9
Day 7	Persevere in the Holy, God-Breathed Scriptures 2 Timothy 3:10–17
Day 8	Proclaim the Word and Finish the Race 2 Timothy 4:1–8
Day 9	Alone in the Dungeon, but the Lord Stands by Me 2 Timothy 4:9–22
	The whole of Second Timothy

DAY 1

Rekindle the Gift of God

SCRIPTURE

2 Timothy 1:1–7

[1] Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus through the will of God, in keeping
with the promise of the life that is in Christ Jesus, [2] to Timothy, my
beloved child: grace, mercy and peace from God the Father and Christ
Jesus our Lord.

[3] I am grateful to God, whom I serve with a clear conscience as my fore-
fathers did, when I remember you without ceasing in my prayers, night
and day. [4] I long to see you – I remember your tears – so that I may be
filled with joy, [5] for I have been reminded of the sincere faith that is in
you, a faith that lived first in your grandmother Lois and in your mother
Eunice, and I am convinced that it lives in you as well. [6] For this reason I
remind you to rekindle the gift of God that is in you through the laying
on of my hands. [7] For God did not give us a spirit of cowardice, but of
power and of love and of self-control.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today we begin a nine-day journey through Paul's second letter to Timothy – a letter about faithfulness to the end, written by an apostle who can already see the end of his own race.

With the opening of 2 Timothy we enter a very different world from that of 1 Timothy. When Paul wrote his first letter (around AD 62–64), he was a free man, hoping to visit Timothy in Ephesus soon. But in the few years that followed, the political and spiritual climate of the Roman Empire changed dramatically. After the great fire of Rome broke out in AD 64, the emperor Nero put the blame on the Christians. Suddenly, confessing the name of Christ could cost you your life.

Paul was arrested again – possibly in Troas, where he left his cloak and books behind (cf. 4:13) – and taken to Rome. This time he was not in a comfortable rented house under house arrest, as at the end of Acts; he was in chains (1:16), treated like a criminal (2:9), and expecting his execution (4:6). Tradition places him in a cold, damp underground dungeon, the Mamertine Prison. This letter, probably written around AD 66–67, is Paul's swan song – his spiritual testament. And to whom does the old, battle-tested soldier write his last words? To his *"beloved child"* Timothy, whose tears (v. 4) Paul cannot forget, and who was bowed down in Ephesus under enormous pressure and intimidation.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text lays bare the deep emotion and powerful theology of this opening:

- **"The promise of the life" (*kat' epangelian zōēs* – κατ' ἐπαγγελίαν ζωῆς, v. 1):** While the shadow of the executioner's sword hangs over Paul's neck and the smell of death fills his cell, he begins his letter by speaking of *"the promise of the life that is in Christ Jesus"*. Nero could kill Paul's earthly body, but he could never touch the eternal life anchored in Christ.
- **"Sincere faith" (*anypokritou pisteōs* – ἀνυποκρίτου πίστεως, v. 5):** Paul reminds the discouraged Timothy of *"the sincere faith that is in you"* – literally a faith without a mask, without hypocrisy. This faith had a precious family history: it lived first in his Jewish grandmother Lois and his mother Eunice (cf. Acts 16:1), from whom he came to know the sacred writings from childhood (2 Timothy 3:14–15). Yet a grandmother's and a mother's faith does not automatically make anyone a child of God; that is why Paul adds that this same faith now lives personally in Timothy: *"it lives in you as well"*.
- **"Rekindle" (*anazōpyrein to charisma tou theou* – ἀναζωπυρεῖν τὸ χάρισμα τοῦ θεοῦ, v. 6):** Here Paul uses a brilliant, vivid verb that occurs only once in the New Testament: *anazōpyreō*. It is made up of

three parts: *ana* (again / up), *zōos* (alive) and *pyr* (fire). It calls up the picture of someone working a pair of bellows over smouldering coals until the grey ash blows away and the living flame leaps up again. Paul does not say that Timothy's gift (*charisma*) is dead, but that fear, tears and human opposition have let a thick layer of ash settle over his zeal. He must deliberately rake the coals open again and fan them into flame.

- **"A spirit of cowardice" (*pneuma deilias* – πνεῦμα δειλίας, v. 7):** Why was Timothy's fire burning low? Because he was intimidated by persecution from outside and opposition from within. Paul declares: "*For God did not give us a spirit of cowardice*." The Greek word *deilia* does not mean natural human caution or holy reverence (*phobos*), but **cowardice** – the paralysing fear of a soldier who throws down his weapon in battle and shrinks back because he dreads pain or rejection. That cowardice never comes from the Holy Spirit!
- **"Of power and of love and of self-control" (*dynameōs kai agapēs kai sōphronismou* – δυνάμεως καὶ ἀγάπης καὶ σωφρονισμοῦ, v. 7):** Against the paralysis of fear stands the threefold equipment of the Spirit that God has given every believer:
  1. *Dynamis* (power): God's supernatural, inner ability and courage to stand firm when your own strength is spent.
  2. *Agapē* (love): self-giving love for God and people, which sets you free from self-absorption and from the fear of what people can do to you (cf. 1 John 4:18).
  3. *Sōphronismos* (self-control / a sound mind): this word, too, occurs only here in the New Testament. It means a disciplined, calm and clear-thinking mind that does not panic in a crisis or get carried away by emotion, but stays under the rule of Christ's truth.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The promise of eternal life triumphs over every earthly darkness.** Even in a death cell a child of God can overflow with gratitude and peace, because our future is guaranteed by Christ.
2. **A spiritual heritage is a privilege that must be made your own.** God powerfully uses the faithful prayers and teaching of parents and grandparents, but every generation must take up the torch of sincere faith for itself.
3. **Spiritual fire needs daily tending.** Even the most gifted believer's zeal can be smothered under the ash of discouragement and fear if it is not deliberately fanned into flame.
4. **Fear is not overcome by willpower alone, but by the fullness of the Spirit.** Where the Holy Spirit reigns, cowardly shrinking back is replaced by divine power, burning love and a calm, disciplined mind.

Living It Out

How often do we feel exactly like Timothy in Ephesus? You see the hostility of the culture towards biblical truth, you feel the pressure at work or in your family when you want to stand up for Christ, or you are simply emotionally drained after a season of tears and disappointment. Before you know it, a thick layer of grey ash has settled over your spiritual life. You still believe, but the flame of passion, boldness and joy has turned into a dull ember.

Today Paul comes and stands beside you with the bellows of the Word: **Rekindle the gift!** (*Anazōpyrein!*) A campfire dies by itself if you do nothing; it only keeps burning if you push the coals together, shake off the ash and add fresh wood. How do you do that spiritually? By refusing to sink into passivity, by getting back on your knees, by opening the Scriptures, and by starting again to serve with the gifts God has given you.

Look honestly, too, at the role of **fear** in your life (v. 7). We often have fine excuses for our silence: *"I'm just an introvert"*, or *"I don't want to make people uncomfortable"*, or *"I'm waiting for a better opportunity."* But Paul calls it by its name: when we shrink back from what God has called us to because we are afraid of people's reactions or of failure, that is *deilia* – a spirit of cowardice. And the wonderful news of verse 7 is that you do not have to be a slave to that fear, because it does not come from your Father!

When anxiety or intimidation knocks at your door today, remind yourself who already lives within you: the Spirit of **power** (for your weakness), the Spirit of **love** (to turn your focus away from yourself towards others) and the Spirit of **self-control** (who keeps your thoughts calm and fixed on Jesus in the middle of the storm).

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Who were my Lois and Eunice?** Who sowed the seed of the gospel in my heart – and how am I living today so that I can pass on that same sincere faith to the next generation?
- **Is there ash on the coals?** Is there a layer of "ash" – discouragement, hurt or sluggishness – dampening the spiritual fire and the gifts in my life right now, and what practical step must I take today to fan the flame again?
- **Where does fear paralyse me?** In what specific situation am I letting a "spirit of cowardice" or panic paralyse me, instead of acting out of the power, love and sound mind the Holy Spirit has already given me?

Prayer

> *Heavenly Father, God of life and source of all grace, mercy and peace,*
>
> *I thank you today for the precious gift of a sincere faith. Thank you for every spiritual parent, grandparent and mentor you have placed on my path to pray for me and to live out your truth before me. Help me to carry that torch with the same sincerity and faithfulness.*

Lord, I confess to you that I often let the storms of life, my own tears and the pressure of this world make the fire within me dwindle. I confess that I shrink back so easily into cowardice, fear of people and worry when you call me to stand firm. Forgive me where I have left the gifts you entrusted to me lying under the ash of passivity.

Breathe again today with the breath of your Holy Spirit over the coals of my heart! Blow away the ash of discouragement and let my devotion to Jesus Christ blaze up brightly once more. Today, in the name of Jesus, I reject every spirit of fear and cowardice, and with gratitude I receive what you have given me: your power for my weakness, your burning love that drives out all fear, and a calm, disciplined mind that stands firm on your Word.

In the victorious name of Jesus Christ, our Lord. Amen.

DAY 2

Do Not Be Ashamed of the Testimony

SCRIPTURE

2 Timothy 1:8–18

8 Do not be ashamed, then, of the testimony about our Lord or of me, his
prisoner; rather, share in hardship for the gospel, in the power of God,
9 who saved us and called us with a holy calling, not on the basis of our
works but on the basis of his own purpose and grace, which was given to
us in Christ Jesus before eternal ages, 10 but has now been revealed
through the appearing of our Saviour Jesus Christ, who broke the
power of death and brought life and imperishability to light through
the gospel, 11 for which I was appointed a herald and an apostle and a
teacher. 12 That is why I am suffering these things too; but I am not
ashamed, for I know whom I have believed, and I am convinced that he
is able to guard my entrusted deposit until that day. 13 Hold to the exam-
ple of sound words that you heard from me, in the faith and love that
are in Christ Jesus. 14 Guard the precious thing that has been entrusted
to you, through the Holy Spirit who lives in us.

15 You know that all who are in the province of Asia have turned away
from me, among them Phygelus and Hermogenes. 16 May the Lord grant
mercy to the household of Onesiphorus, for he often refreshed me and
was not ashamed of my chain. 17 On the contrary, when he came to
Rome, he searched hard for me and found me – 18 may the Lord grant
him to find mercy from the Lord on that day! – and you know better
than I do how much he served in Ephesus.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In verse 7 Paul reminded Timothy that God did not give us a spirit of cowardice, but of power, love and self-control. Now he applies this truth directly to Timothy's greatest temptation: the temptation to be **ashamed** of

the gospel and of Paul's imprisonment.

To feel the weight of this, we need to remember that ancient Greco-Roman society was an "honour-and-shame" culture. Public reputation and social standing were everything. And the Christians now carried a double social stigma: they worshipped a Saviour who had died on a Roman cross (the most humiliating form of execution, reserved for slaves and enemies of the state), and their leading messenger, Paul, sat in chains in a Roman death cell under the emperor Nero as a condemned criminal. To identify openly with Paul and his message in that climate meant bringing social rejection, confiscation of property and even arrest upon yourself. Many believers in the province of Asia (whose leading city was Ephesus) gave way under this pressure and turned away from Paul (v. 15). Paul writes to put steel into Timothy's spine, so that he does not walk the same road.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The original Greek text unfolds a breathtaking theological and emotional depth:

- **"Do not be ashamed" (*mē epaischynthēs* – μὴ ἐπαισχυνθῇς, v. 8):** The key word that binds this whole passage together is the verb *epaischynomai* ("to be ashamed"), which occurs three times: as a call to Timothy (v. 8), as Paul's own testimony (v. 12), and as the badge of honour of Onesiphorus (v. 16). It refers to the paralysing embarrassment and fear of human contempt that makes you keep silent when you should speak, or hide when you should stand up. Notice how Paul describes himself: he does not call himself Nero's prisoner, but *"his prisoner"* – the Lord's prisoner. Even his chains are under Christ's sovereign control!
- **"Share in hardship" (*synkakopathēson* – συγκακοπάθησον, v. 8):** Instead of shrinking back, Paul commands Timothy: *"share in hardship for the gospel"*. This single Greek word (*syn* = with; *kakos* = hard, painful; *paschō* = suffer) is not found in earlier Greek writings and may

have been coined by Paul himself. He does not offer Timothy a cheap prosperity gospel of earthly comfort; he invites him to walk shoulder to shoulder with him into the furnace of affliction – not in his own fragile human strength, but *kata dynamin theou*, *"in the power of God"* (the preposition *kata* literally means "according to").

- **"Before eternal ages" (*pro chronōn aiōniōn* – πρὸ χρόνων αἰωνίων, v. 9):** Where does a person find the courage to suffer for the gospel? By looking at the eternal greatness of our salvation! God saved us and called us – not on the basis of our own works or achievements, but on the basis of his own purpose and grace, which was given to us *"before eternal ages"* (before creation or time itself existed). Your salvation was not God's emergency plan; it was settled in Christ before the foundation of the world.
- **"Broke the power of death ... brought life and imperishability to light" (*katargēsantos men ton thanaton phōtisantos de zōēn kai aphtharsian* – καταργήσαντος μὲν τὸν θάνατον φωτίσαντος δὲ ζωὴν καὶ ἀφθαρσίαν, v. 10):** This eternal grace broke visibly into history with the appearing (*epiphaneia*) of Jesus Christ. Through his death on the cross and his resurrection, Christ *"broke the power of death"* (*katargeō*). This forceful verb does not mean that death has ceased to exist, but that it has been disarmed, rendered powerless and robbed of its sting. At the same time he *"brought ... to light"* (*phōtizō* – like a sharp spotlight lighting up a dark room) life and *aphtharsia* – *"imperishability"*, a state in which nothing can decay or rot any more. (*Aphtharsia* is not the same word as *athanasia*, "immortality", in 1 Timothy 6:16.) Nero's sword has lost its terror, for to the believer death is merely the passage to imperishable glory.
- **"My entrusted deposit" and "the precious thing that has been entrusted to you" (*tēn parathēkēn mou / tēn kalēn parathēkēn* – τὴν παραθήκην μου / τὴν καλὴν παραθήκην, vv. 12 and 14):** Once again Paul uses the banking and legal term *parathēkē* – a deposit handed over to someone for safekeeping (cf. 1 Timothy 6:20). In verse 12 he says that

God *"is able to guard my entrusted deposit until that day"*. The Greek leaves two readings open. It may refer to what Paul has entrusted to God – his own soul, his ministry and his eternal future, placed as a deposit in God's hands with rock-solid certainty that God will keep it until the day of judgement. Or it may refer to what God has entrusted to Paul – the gospel itself, as in verse 14 and in 1 Timothy 6:20 – with the certainty that God will protect his own message even when his messenger is in chains. Both readings bring comfort. In verse 14 the meaning is clear: God, for his part, has given us *"the precious thing that has been entrusted to you"* – sound teaching, the *hypotypōsis* or fixed pattern of verse 13 – to guard through the power of the indwelling Holy Spirit.

- **"Refreshed" (*anepsyxen* – ἀνέψυξεν, v. 16):** At the end of the chapter Paul paints two sharp portraits. On one side stand Phygelus and Hermogenes – two names from Asia, singled out among those who turned their backs on Paul in his hour of need. On the other side stands **Onesiphorus**. When he arrived in Rome he must have known how dangerous it was to ask after a state prisoner, but he kept searching until he found Paul. Paul says: *"he often refreshed me"*. The verb *anapsychō* literally means to cool off, or to catch your breath again after almost suffocating in the heat. In that stuffy, dark dungeon the presence of Onesiphorus was like a cool, life-giving breeze of God's love.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The gospel is the power of God that has defeated death.** We have no reason ever to be ashamed of the message of the cross, for it is the only message that rescues humanity from the power of death and gives eternal imperishability.
2. **Eternal security breeds present courage.** When you know that your salvation was anchored in God's grace before the creation of the world (v. 9), and that he safely guards what has been entrusted until that day (v. 12), people's threats lose their power over you.

3. **Know the Person behind the promise.** Paul's boldness in the dungeon flows from an intimate, personal knowledge: *"I know **whom** I have believed"*. Faith does not rest merely on a system of facts, but on the living, almighty Person of Jesus Christ.
4. **Loyalty to Christ includes loyalty to his suffering people.** You cannot say you are not ashamed of Jesus while you are ashamed of his persecuted or despised children. Real faith shows its face in practical, self-sacrificing mercy like that of Onesiphorus.

Living It Out

In our modern society few of us are threatened with physical chains and underground dungeons, but the subtle tyranny of **shame** is just as real today as in the first century. We live in a culture that permits and applauds everything except the exclusive truth claims of the Bible. When you stand at work, on a university campus or around a barbecue today and it becomes clear that you believe in the authority of Scripture, in biblical sexuality, or that Jesus Christ is the only way to salvation, you are often looked at as if you were intolerant, old-fashioned or intellectually backward.

In those moments the spirit of *Phygelus and Hermogenes* knocks at our heart. We are tempted to keep quiet when our Lord's name is taken in vain, to laugh along at a dirty joke so as not to stand out, or to hide our Christian convictions so that we do not lose social standing or a promotion at work.

How do you overcome this paralysing embarrassment? Paul gives us two anchors:

1. **Look at what Christ has done for you (vv. 9–10):** He was not ashamed of you when he hung naked and bleeding on the cross to bear your guilt and destroy death for you. How then can we be ashamed of *him* before people whose breath is in their nostrils?

2. **Look at the example of Onesiphorus (vv. 16–18):** Be someone who moves in when others walk away. When a fellow believer goes through a season of deep trial – illness, depression, financial loss or rejection – "fair-weather friends" often shrug and disappear. But a spiritual friend deliberately walks into the dark room, sits down beside the broken person without being ashamed of their "chains", and brings the refreshing, cool breeze (*anapsychō*) of Christ's presence.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Where am I ashamed?** In what setting, or in front of which people, do I currently find it hardest to stand openly and without embarrassment as a follower of Jesus Christ?
- **Is my life in his hands?** Have I handed over my whole life – my soul, my future, my reputation and my loved ones – as a deposit entrusted completely into God's hands, with the rock-solid conviction that he is able to guard it until that day?
- **Who needs an Onesiphorus?** Who in my world feels lonely, forgotten or "chained" by hardship today – someone I could seek out this week, like Onesiphorus, and refresh?

Prayer

> *Almighty God and Father, you who knew me, loved me and called me with a holy calling in Christ Jesus before the foundation of the world,*
>
> *I bow today in deep wonder before your grace. I know that I had nothing in my hands to earn your favour; my salvation is from beginning to end the work of your eternal purpose and of the precious blood of my Saviour Jesus Christ, who broke the power of death and brought imperishable life to light.*
>
> *Lord, forgive me for every time I kept silent before people when I should have stood up for you. Forgive me for the times I cared more about the approval of a passing world than about the honour of your name. Deliver me*

from the cowardice of Phygelus and Hermogenes, which gives way when the road of discipleship becomes hard or unpopular.

Give me today the unshakeable boldness of Paul, so that in the middle of every storm I can cry out: I am not ashamed, for I know whom I have believed! Today I place my life, my soul and everything precious to me afresh as an entrusted deposit into your almighty hands, and I ask you to help me, through the indwelling Holy Spirit, to guard the precious deposit of your pure Word, entrusted to me, unharmed.

Make me an Onesiphorus this week too, Lord – give me eyes to see those who are in darkness and trial, and use me to be a cool breeze of your comfort and mercy to them.

In the mighty name of Jesus Christ, the Victor over death. Amen.

DAY 3

Strengthened by Grace: Soldier, Athlete and Farmer

SCRIPTURE

2 Timothy 2:1–7

[1] You then, my child, be strengthened by the grace that is in Christ
Jesus. [2] And the things you heard from me through many witnesses –
entrust these to faithful people who will be competent to teach others
too. [3] Share in hardship as a good soldier of Christ Jesus. [4] No one serv-
ing as a soldier gets entangled in the affairs of everyday life, since he
wants to please the one who enlisted him. [5] Likewise, anyone who com-
petes as an athlete is not crowned unless he competes according to the
rules. [6] The farmer who works hard ought to be the first to receive a
share of the crops. [7] Think about what I am saying, for the Lord will give
you understanding in everything.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

At the end of chapter 1 Paul contrasted the painful defection of those in Asia (such as Phygelus and Hermogenes) with the self-sacrificing loyalty of Onesiphorus. Now he opens chapter 2 with the words: "*You then, my child*" (*sy oun, teknon mou*). Over against those who deserted the fight out of fear, Timothy must stand firm.

Paul knows that his own life will soon be ended by the sword of Rome. The burning question in the old apostle's heart is: **How will the gospel survive and go forward when I am no longer here?** His answer in these seven verses is one of the most strategic passages in the whole New Testament. The survival of the truth rests on two pillars: spiritual multi-

plication (discipleship) and unwavering endurance – which Paul illustrates with three everyday occupations: the soldier, the athlete and the farmer.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text opens up the richness of these instructions:

- **"Be strengthened by the grace" (*endynamou en tē chariti* – ἐνδυναμοῦ ἐν τῇ χάριτι, v. 1):** Our translation says *"be strengthened by the grace"*, because the Greek verb *endynamoō* stands here in the **present tense** and in a form usually understood as **passive**. It means: *"Keep on letting yourself be made strong by the grace that is in Christ Jesus."* Paul is not asking Timothy to grit his teeth and be strong out of his own exhausted willpower. Spiritual strength is not generated from within; it is received from outside, by plugging in daily to the inexhaustible power source of Christ's grace.
- **"Entrust these to faithful people" (*parathou pistois anthrōpois* – παράθου πιστοῖς ἀνθρώποις, v. 2):** Here Paul gives the blueprint for spiritual reproduction across **four generations**: (1) Paul hands the truth on to (2) Timothy, who must entrust it (*paratithēmi* – the same root as *parathēkē*, "the precious thing that has been entrusted", of 1:14) to (3) *"faithful people who will be competent to teach others too"* (4). Notice the order of the requirements: Paul is not looking first for brilliant, charismatic or influential people, but for **faithful** (*pistois*) ones. Reliability and character always come before competence (*hikanoi*).
- **Picture 1: The soldier – undivided focus (*stratiōtēs* – στρατιώτης, vv. 3–4):** A good soldier of Christ does not expect a soft life of ease; he is ready to share in hardship (*synkakopathēson*). His secret is that he does not get *"entangled in the affairs of everyday life"* (*empleketai* – ἐμπλέκεται – like a sheep caught in a thorn bush, or a piece of weaving tangled into knots), that is, in civilian business and worldly distractions. His one motivation is his commander: *"he wants to please the one who enlisted him"* (tō *stratologēsanti* – τῷ στρατολογήσαντι).

- **Picture 2: The athlete – discipline according to the rules (*athleō* – ἀθλέω, v. 5):** From the battlefield Paul moves to the stadium. Anyone who competes "is not crowned" (*stephanoutai* – στεφανοῦται) "unless he competes according to the rules" (*nomimōs* – νομίμως). At the ancient Olympic Games, according to the Greek writer Pausanias, athletes had to swear an oath before the statue of Zeus that they had trained strictly by the prescribed rules for ten months; and in the contest itself they were not allowed to take any shortcuts. Unlike the false teachers, who took moral and doctrinal shortcuts to win quick popularity, the servant of God must run with holy integrity within the lines of God's Word.
- **Picture 3: The farmer – patient, exhausting labour (*ton kopiōnta geōrgon* – τὸν κοπιῶντα γεωργὸν, v. 6):** The soldier knows the thrill of battle and the athlete the cheers of the crowd, but in the third picture Paul takes us to the quiet, dusty field of the farmer (*geōrgos*). The emphasis falls on the participle *ton kopiōnta* – "who works hard" (to the point of physical exhaustion). There is nothing glamorous about ploughing in the early hours, sowing, pulling weeds and waiting patiently for months for rain. Yet the promise stands: the farmer who does not give up will in the end be the first to share in the joy of the harvest (*tōn karpōn*, "the crops").
- **"Think about what I am saying" (*noei ho legō* – νόει ὃ λέγω, v. 7):** Paul closes with a beautiful balance between human responsibility and divine working: "Think about what I am saying" – use your mind to ponder these pictures deeply – "for the Lord will give you understanding in everything". The word for understanding, *synesis* (σύνεσιν), is the ability to connect the dots and apply them in practice.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Grace is not only the starting point of salvation, but the daily power source for service.** We do not win by trying harder in our own strength, but by drinking more deeply of Christ's grace.

2. **The gospel is a relay baton, not a museum piece.** Every believer is a link in a chain. If we enjoy the truth only for ourselves without deliberately investing it in faithful people, we break the chain of spiritual multiplication.
3. **Spiritual endurance needs the heart of a soldier, an athlete and a farmer.** It calls for the soldier's freedom from worldly entanglement, the athlete's refusal to compromise with God's rules, and the farmer's patience to keep slogging on when results are slow to show.
4. **Spiritual insight is born where prayerful reflection and the Holy Spirit meet.** God does not give mature insight to the lazy person who will not ponder the Word, but our own reflection is blind without the Lord's illumination.

Living It Out

These seven verses cut straight to the root of our spiritual weariness and our purpose in life.

Do you feel exhausted today in your faith, your parenting or your ministry? The reason is often that we try to be strong *for* God instead of being strengthened *in his grace* (v. 1). We carry loads on our own shoulders that were never meant to be carried without his strength. To be strengthened by grace means admitting your own bankruptcy before the Lord this morning and breathing in his abundant forgiveness and strength like oxygen.

Second, look at verse 2: **Whose life are you investing in right now?** The church is always just one generation away from extinction. You do not have to be a pastor in a pulpit to be a spiritual mentor. It could be a younger colleague at work, your own children or grandchildren, or a young believer nearby with whom you have a cup of coffee every two weeks to open the Scriptures and pray together. Don't take your life experience and the truth God has taught you with you to the grave – pass on the baton!

Finally, let the three mirrors of verses 3 to 6 examine your life:

- **The soldier:** What have you become entangled (*empleketai*) in? Many things in life are not sinful in themselves – hobbies, career ambitions, social media, possessions – but if they have wound themselves so tightly around your feet that you are no longer free to carry out your Commander's orders, you have lost your focus.
- **The athlete:** Are you tempted to take "shortcuts"? In a world that wants instant results, we often want the crown without the discipline of holiness and obedience to God's Word.
- **The farmer:** Perhaps you have been sowing for years with tears and sweat – you pray for a family member who does not yet know Christ, you serve faithfully in a thankless setting, or you raise your children without seeing fruit straight away. Don't let go of the plough! The harvest comes in God's time, and whoever has worked hard will be the first to share in the joy.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Willpower or grace?** Am I trying to carry out my spiritual duties in my own human willpower at the moment, or am I drawing fresh strength every day from the grace of Jesus Christ?
- **Who are my faithful people?** Who are the one or two "faithful people" in my world in whom I am deliberately investing right now, so that the truth of the gospel is passed on to the next generation?
- **Soldier, athlete or farmer?** Which of the three challenges speaks loudest to my heart today: the soldier who must free himself from worldly entanglement, the athlete who must stop looking for shortcuts, or the farmer who must keep ploughing patiently without immediate applause?

Prayer

Lord Jesus Christ, my Commander-in-Chief and the source of all grace,

I come to you today with the honest confession that in myself I am weak and quickly exhausted. Thank you that you do not expect me to overcome in my own strength, but that you invite me to be strengthened continually by the infinite grace that is found in you. Fill me afresh today with your strength.

Lord, open my eyes to the people around me to whom I can pass on the precious treasure of your Word. Keep me from a self-centred faith that ends with me; make me a faithful link that hands the torch of truth on to the next generation.

Give me the undivided heart of a good soldier: cut every rope of worldly entanglement and worry that keeps me from living wholeheartedly for your kingdom, so that my one desire is to please you. Give me the self-discipline of an athlete never to take moral or spiritual shortcuts, but to walk in everything according to the rules of your Word. And give me the tough endurance of a farmer to keep sowing and working, even when the ground is hard and the harvest still seems far away. Give me understanding in all these things by your Spirit.

In your mighty and faithful name. Amen.

DAY 4

The Word of God Is Not Chained

SCRIPTURE

2 Timothy 2:8–13

8 Remember Jesus Christ, raised from the dead, descended from David,
according to my gospel. 9 For this gospel I am enduring hardship, even
to the point of being chained like a criminal. But the word of God is not
chained. 10 That is why I endure all things for the sake of the chosen, so
that they too may obtain the salvation that is in Christ Jesus, with eter-
nal glory. 11 This is a trustworthy saying:

For if we died with him,
we will also live with him;
12 if we endure,
we will also reign with him;
if we will deny him,
he also will deny us;
13 if we are faithless,
he remains faithful –
for he cannot deny himself.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In the first seven verses of chapter 2 Paul called Timothy to persevere with the single-minded focus of a soldier, the self-discipline of an athlete and the stubborn endurance of a farmer. Now he points him to the highest Example and the deepest motive for perseverance: **Jesus Christ himself.**

Picture the scene. Paul sits in a dark cell in Rome – by tradition an underground dungeon. His wrists are chafed raw by heavy iron chains. Under Roman law he is classed as a criminal dangerous to the state, awaiting his sentence. To the outside world – and even to frightened Christians in

Ephesus – it looked as though Paul's ministry had ended in tragic failure. Yet from that damp dungeon rises no lament, but a shout of victory that has echoed down the centuries.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text unfolds the power of these six verses in a breathtaking way:

- **"Remember Jesus Christ, raised from the dead" (*Mnēmoneue Iēsoun Christon egēgermenon ek nekrōn* – Μνημόνευε Ἰησοῦν Χριστὸν ἐγηγερμένον ἐκ νεκρῶν, v. 8):** The verb *mnēmoneuō* ("remember, keep in mind") is a present imperative: keep Jesus Christ continually before your mind's eye! When fear and exhaustion overwhelm you, what you need is not new information but a living reminder of the person of Christ. Notice the two descriptions: he is "descended from David" (confirming his true humanity, his humiliation and his rightful claim to the messianic throne), and he is "raised from the dead". In Greek *egēgermenon* is a perfect participle: he was raised in the past and **is still the living, risen Victor**. Jesus is not a dead martyr who merely inspires us; he is the living King who stands beside us.
- **"Like a criminal" (*hōs kakourgos* – ὡς κακοῦργος, v. 9):** Paul says he wears chains "like a criminal". In the whole New Testament the word *kakourgos* occurs only here and in Luke 23:32, 33 and 39, where it describes the two criminals crucified on either side of Jesus. Rome treated the church's greatest apostle like the lowest highway robber.
- **"But the word of God is not chained" (*alla ho logos tou theou ou dedetai* – ἀλλὰ ὁ λόγος τοῦ θεοῦ οὐ δέδεται, v. 9):** In Greek this is a moving play on words and a sharp contrast. Paul is bound "even to the point of being chained" (*mechri desmōn* – μέχρι δεσμῶν), but the word of God *ou dedetai* – it stands permanently free, untamed and unchained. Emperors and dictators can lock up preachers, burn down church buildings and ban Bibles, but they can no more chain the living voice of God than they can tie down the sunrise with a rope.

- **"For the sake of the chosen" (*dia tous eklektous* – διὰ τοὺς ἐκλεκτούς, v. 10):** Why does Paul bear all this humiliation without flinching? "That is why I endure all things for the sake of the chosen" (*hypomenō* – ὑπομένω). Paul understands that God's sovereign election does not make human sacrifice and evangelism unnecessary. On the contrary, God uses precisely the proclamation and the suffering of his servants as the means of bringing his chosen children to faith, salvation and "eternal glory" (*doxa aiōnios*).
- **The fourfold martyrs' hymn (vv. 11–13):** Here Paul quotes the fourth "trustworthy saying" (*pistos ho logos* – πιστὸς ὁ λόγος) of the Pastoral Letters – an early Christian hymn of faith made up of four matching lines of two parts each:
  1. *The foundation of union (v. 11b):* "If we died with him, we will also live with him" (*synapethanomen* – συναπεθάνομεν; *syzēsomen* – συζήσομεν). This refers to our union with Christ's death in new birth and baptism (cf. Romans 6:8), as well as to the willingness to lay down our lives for him physically. Dying with Christ always ends in eternal life with him.
  2. *The promise for endurance (v. 12a):* "If we endure, we will also reign with him" (*hypomenomen* – ὑπομένομεν, keeping on holding out in the present; *symbasileusomen* – συμβασιλεύσομεν). The road to the throne runs through the cross. Today's chains become tomorrow's crowns.
  3. *The warning against falling away (v. 12b):* "If we will deny him, he also will deny us" (*arnēsometha* – ἀρνησόμεθα, future tense). This is a direct echo of Jesus' own words in Matthew 10:33. It does not refer to a momentary stumble like Peter's that ends in repentance, but to a final, persistent rejection of Christ in order to save your own skin in this world.
  4. *The anchor of God's character (v. 13):* "If we are faithless, he remains faithful – for he cannot deny himself" (*apistoumen* – ἀπιστοῦμεν; *pistos menei* – πιστὸς μένει). Some interpreters see this as a warning:

God remains faithful to his righteous judgment even when people are faithless. But in the pastoral setting of Timothy's fear and weakness it carries overwhelming comfort: when our faith wavers and our human weakness lets us down, it never changes who Christ is. His covenant faithfulness does not depend on how unsteady our grip on him is, but on his unshakeable grip on us – for unfaithfulness is impossible for his holy nature!

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **A tormented memory must be filled with the risen Christ.** The best medicine for a discouraged heart is to stop deliberately at the empty tomb and before the living person of Jesus.
2. **Our limits are never God's limits.** Your body may lie on a sickbed and your circumstances may hem you in, but God's Word still moves freely and powerfully to change hearts.
3. **Our suffering has a saving echo in the lives of others.** When you stay faithful in trial, God uses your endurance as a testimony to draw others towards eternal glory.
4. **Our security rests ultimately in Christ's unchanging nature.** Even on our weakest days we stand on the rock of a Redeemer who can never deny himself.

Living It Out

How easily we forget the simplest command in the Bible: "**Remember Jesus Christ!**" (v. 8). When a crisis hits us – a financial setback, strain in a marriage, a hostile workplace or a worrying medical report – our problems grow so large that they fill our whole field of vision. We remember our fears, we remember our mistakes, and we remember what people have done to us, but we forget that Jesus Christ has been raised from the

dead and reigns today with all authority in heaven and on earth! To "remember" Jesus means deliberately turning your eyes away from your bars today and fixing them on his victory.

Perhaps you feel "chained" in some way today. Perhaps you are limited by chronic pain, by age, by family responsibilities that keep you at home, or by a workplace where you may not speak freely about your faith. Take courage from verse 9: **You may be confined, but the word of God is not chained!** While Paul was in chains, his letters flew through the bars to save millions of people over two thousand years; and during an earlier imprisonment it became known throughout the whole imperial guard that he was in chains for Christ (Philippians 1:12–13). Your prayers, your smile in the midst of pain, and a single verse of Scripture shared with someone carry an unstoppable power that no wall can hold back.

Finally, let the hymn of verses 11 to 13 both shake you awake and comfort you today. It shakes us awake, because cheap nominal Christianity that denies Christ as soon as it becomes uncomfortable has no future. But if you are a child of God today, wrestling with your own faltering faith – if you look at your weaknesses and your stumbling and wonder whether the Lord has grown tired of you – hear the wonderful gospel of verse 13: when our faith is faint and shaky, he remains faithful! He cannot do otherwise than be faithful to the child he bought with his own blood, for to push you away when you cry out to him in your weakness would mean denying himself.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- When I go through a hard season or opposition, what dominates my thoughts: the size of my circumstances, or the living reality of the risen Jesus Christ?
- Is there a situation in which I currently feel that my hands are tied or "chained"? How can I trust that God's unchained Word will reach its goal even through my limitations?

- Does my deepest assurance of faith rest today on my own ability always to stand strong, or do I rest in the unchanging faithfulness of a Redeemer who can never deny himself?

Prayer

Risen and living Lord Jesus Christ, Son of David and King of eternity, forgive me for forgetting so quickly who you are when the storms of life break around me. I confess that my eyes so easily stay fixed on my own chains, my limits and my fears, as though I served a dead Redeemer. Help me today to keep you continually before my eyes – you who broke open the grave and live for ever!

I praise you that your Word cannot be chained by any human power, any hostile culture or any difficult circumstance. Use my life – even my trials and the places where I am hurt – so that others may come to know the salvation and the eternal glory that are in you. Give me the grace to endure all things patiently for the sake of those you still want to draw to yourself.

Lord, I thank you from the depths of my soul for the promise that, because I have died with you, I will also live and reign with you for ever. And when my own strength runs low and my faith wavers, I thank you that your faithfulness never changes. Hold me fast in your grace, for you cannot deny yourself. In your invincible and faithful name. Amen.

DAY 5

An Approved Worker and a Vessel for Honour

SCRIPTURE

2 Timothy 2:14–26

14 Keep reminding them of these things, and solemnly charge them before the Lord not to fight about words; it is of no use and only ruins those who listen. 15 Make every effort to present yourself to God as approved, a worker with nothing to be ashamed of, who handles the word of truth accurately. 16 But avoid irreverent, empty chatter, for those who indulge in it will advance further and further into ungodliness, 17 and their talk will spread like gangrene. Among them are Hymenaeus and Philetus, 18 who have missed the mark concerning the truth by saying that the resurrection has already taken place, and they are overturning the faith of some. 19 Yet the solid foundation laid by God stands firm, and it bears this seal: "The Lord knows who are his," and: "Everyone who names the name of the Lord must turn away from wrongdoing."

20 In a large house you find not only vessels of gold and silver, but also vessels of wood and clay – some meant for honour, others for dishonour. 21 So if anyone purifies himself from these, he will be a vessel meant for honour – consecrated, useful to the master, prepared for every good work. 22 Flee from the desires of youth, and pursue righteousness, faith, love and peace, together with those who call on the Lord out of a pure heart. 23 Refuse foolish and uninstructed controversies, knowing that they give rise to quarrels. 24 And a servant of the Lord must not quarrel, but be kind to everyone, able to teach, patient when wronged, 25 instructing with gentleness those who oppose him, in the hope that God may grant them repentance that leads to the knowledge of the truth, 26 and they will come to their senses and escape from the trap of the devil, having been taken captive by him for his will.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In the previous verses Paul encouraged Timothy with the truth that the word of God can never be chained and that Christ remains completely faithful (2:8–13). Now he turns his gaze back to the threat inside the church in Ephesus. The false teachings had not disappeared since his first letter; on the contrary, they had spread like a deadly infection.

Hymenaeus – very probably the same man whom Paul had already placed under church discipline in 1 Timothy 1:20 – had not repented. Together with a new ally, Philetus, he was spreading a false teaching that can be seen as a forerunner of later Gnosticism. They claimed "that the resurrection has already taken place" (v. 18). Under the influence of Greek philosophy, which regarded the physical body as inferior, they probably taught that the resurrection was only an inner, spiritual awakening at baptism or conversion, and that there would be no future bodily resurrection from the dead. This teaching attacked the heart of the gospel and was overturning the faith of some church members. In this tense climate Paul uses three powerful images to equip Timothy: the **craftsman** (vv. 14–18), the **household vessel** (vv. 19–21) and the **gentle servant** (vv. 22–26).

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text opens up the richness of this passage:

- **"Not to fight about words" (*logomachein* – λογομαχεῖν; *katastrophē* – καταστροφῇ, v. 14):** Timothy must "solemnly charge them before the Lord not to fight about words" (*logomacheō* – waging war with mere words and philosophical speculation). Such debates build no one up; "it is of no use and only ruins those who listen" – *katastrophē* means ruin or total collapse, the exact opposite of spiritual upbuilding.
- **"A worker with nothing to be ashamed of" (*dokimon … ergatēn* – δόκιμον … ἐργάτην; *orthotomounta* – ὀρθοτομοῦντα, v. 15):** In contrast to the chattering false teachers, Timothy must make every effort

to stand before God as *dokimos* – "approved", tested like gold that has been through the fire and found genuine – a worker "who handles the word of truth accurately". The Greek participle *orthotomounta* (*orthos* = straight; *temnō* = to cut) occurs only here in the New Testament and literally means "cutting straight". Interpreters think of various pictures: a stonemason squaring a block so that it fits the building exactly, a ploughman drawing a dead-straight furrow across the field, a road-builder laying a straight path (cf. Proverbs 3:6 in the Greek translation), or a tentmaker (Paul's own trade) cutting pieces of material straight along a precise pattern. While false teachers twist Scripture and cut it crooked to fit their own ideas, the faithful servant must handle the Word with accuracy, honesty and without additions.

- **"Like gangrene" (*hōs gangraina* – ὡς γάγγραινα, v. 17):** Where older translations speak of "canker" or "cancer", the Greek uses the medical term *gangraina* – gangrene. It describes dying tissue that spreads rapidly to healthy parts of the body and leads to death unless it is stopped. False teaching is never an innocent theological difference of opinion; it eats away the spiritual life of a congregation.
- **"The solid foundation laid by God" (*stereos themelios* – στερεὸς θεμέλιος; *sphragida* – σφραγῖδα, v. 19):** When people like Hymenaeus and Philetus fall away, it can look as though the church is crumbling. Yet Paul gives a rock-solid assurance: "Yet the solid foundation laid by God stands firm"! In the ancient world an inscription or seal (*sphragis*) was sometimes placed on the foundation stone or cornerstone of a building to indicate ownership and purpose. God's foundation bears a double inscription that points back to Korah's rebellion in Numbers 16 – the first is a quotation of Numbers 16:5, the second an allusion to Numbers 16:26 (cf. Isaiah 52:11):
  1. *The invisible, divine side (eternal security):* "The Lord knows who are his." No false teacher can snatch a true child of God out of his hand.

2. *The visible, human side (practical holiness)*: "Everyone who names the name of the Lord must turn away from wrongdoing." True election is always shown by a life that turns away from sin.

- **"A vessel meant for honour" (*skeuos eis timēn* – σκεῦος εἰς τιμήν, vv. 20–21):** Paul compares the visible church to a "large house" with gold and silver dishes for honourable use at the dining table, as well as wooden and clay pots for dishonourable use (carrying out rubbish and waste). But then Paul makes a surprising turn: unlike a lifeless clay pot that can never become gold, *anyone* who "purifies himself from these" (*ekkathairō* – ἐκκαθαίρω, to clean out thoroughly) – from the false teachers and their ungodliness – "will be a vessel meant for honour – consecrated, useful to the master" (*euchrēston* – εὔχρηστον, highly useful and serviceable in the hand of the Master of the house).
- **Kind, patient and gentle (*ēpion* – ἤπιον; *anexikakon* – ἀνεξίκακον; *en praütēti* – ἐν πραΰτητι, vv. 24–26):** How should Timothy treat those who have been misled by false teaching and argue against him? A servant (*doulos*) of the Lord must not quarrel (*machesthai* – μάχεσθαι), but must be *ēpios* (tender and kind, like a caring parent), able to teach, and *anexikakos* – "patient when wronged", able to bear evil without taking revenge or growing bitter. He must correct opponents "with gentleness" (*praütēs* – strength under control). Why? Because only God can grant repentance (*metanoia*) in a person's heart, so that those who have been misled "come to their senses" (*ananēphō* – to sober up, to wake from drunkenness or a stupor) and escape the trap in which the devil has taken them captive alive (*ezōgrēmenoi* – ἐζωγρημένοι).

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Careful handling of Scripture is our best defence against deception.** We need not get drawn into pointless arguments; our task is to open up God's Word straight and pure, so that the truth itself exposes the lie.

2. **God's sovereignty and human holiness are two sides of the same coin.** We rest in the comfort that the Lord knows who are his, and we show that we are his by deliberately breaking with wrongdoing.
3. **Purity determines usefulness.** God does not choose golden vessels on the basis of human intelligence or status; he uses the vessel that has been washed clean and set apart for his hand.
4. **The method of our ministry must match the message of grace.** You cannot free people from the trap of the devil by fighting them with fleshly anger and quarrelsomeness; only patient teaching, gentleness and prayer open the way for God to grant repentance.

Living It Out

This passage searches our hearts, our handling of the Bible and our relationships with people who differ from us.

First, ask yourself: **Am I a craftsman who handles the word of truth accurately (v. 15)?** We live in a time when even Christians often treat the Bible like a collection of loose quotations to prove their own preconceived opinions. To be an approved worker with nothing to be ashamed of before the Master on the day of judgment means bowing before the text with reverence, study and honesty – even when the Word challenges our comfort zones.

Second, look at the vivid picture of the **vessels in the large house** (vv. 20–22). Do you want your life to be truly *useful* (*euchrēston*) to the Lord? The secret lies in daily cleansing. Notice what Paul warns against in verse 22: "Flee from the desires of youth." We usually think straight away of sexual temptations, and these are certainly included. But in the context of this chapter the "desires of youth" also refer to the typical urges of an immature spirit: impatience, opinionatedness, the urge to win every argument, a quick temper and pride! Notice too that you don't have to run alone:

pursue righteousness, faith, love and peace "**together with those who call on the Lord out of a pure heart**". You need holy friends and a healthy community of faith to stay on the right path.

Finally, verses 24 to 26 change the way we look at family members, colleagues or church people caught up in false teaching, worldly ideologies or hostility towards the truth. Our fleshly reaction is to fight with them (*machomai*), to demolish them verbally on social media or at the dinner table, and to get angry when they treat us badly. But Paul shows us their true condition: they are spiritually intoxicated and stuck in the trap of the devil! You don't free a wounded prisoner of war by beating him with a stick. We are called to share the truth with supernatural kindness (*ēpios*), patience under wrong (*anexikakos*) and gentleness, while pleading on our knees that God will work the miracle of repentance and awakening in their hearts.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Do I approach the Bible with the diligence and integrity of a craftsman who wants to handle the word of truth accurately, or do I spend my energy on pointless controversies that bring division rather than upbuilding?
- From which specific things, habits or attitudes ("desires of youth") must I thoroughly cleanse myself today, so that I can be a clean, useful vessel for honour in my Master's hand?
- When someone opposes me or is hostile towards my faith, do I react with quarrelsomeness and self-defence, or with the gentleness and patience of a servant who prays for their spiritual freedom?

Prayer

> *Lord God, Master of the large house and Rock on whose solid foundation my life is built, I thank you with all my heart for the double seal of your covenant: today I rest in the wonderful knowledge that you know me by*

name and that I belong to you, and I bow before your call to turn away from every form of wrongdoing.

Lord, make me an approved worker who never needs to be ashamed before your face. Give me a deep love and reverence for your Word, so that I handle the truth straight and pure and flee far from the empty, harmful reasoning of this world. Wash me thoroughly clean today from every hidden sin, from selfishness and from the youthful craving for my own glory. Make me a golden vessel for your honour – consecrated, clean and wholly useful in your hand for every good work you bring across my path.

Lord Jesus, give me your own mind when I deal with difficult or wandering people. Deliver me from a quarrelsome, impatient spirit that always wants to win. Clothe me with your kindness, your ability to bear wrong without bitterness, and your gentleness. Use my words and my prayers to point those caught in the enemy's trap lovingly towards the light, and grant them repentance yourself, so that they may awaken to the true knowledge of your grace. In your holy and precious name. Amen.

DAY 6

Difficult Times and a Show of Godliness

SCRIPTURE

2 Timothy 3:1–9

[1] But understand this: in the last days difficult times will come. [2] For people will be lovers of themselves, lovers of money, boastful, arrogant, blasphemers, disobedient to their parents, ungrateful, unholy, [3] heartless, irreconcilable, slanderers, without self-restraint, brutal, haters of what is good, [4] treacherous, reckless, puffed up, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God, [5] having an outward form of godliness but denying its power. Turn away from such people! [6] For among them are those who worm their way into households and take captive weak women, who are weighed down with sins and driven by all kinds of desires, [7] always learning and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth. [8] Just as Jannes and Jambres opposed Moses, so these also oppose the truth: people corrupted in mind, who have failed the test regarding the faith. [9] But they will not get very far, for their folly will become plain to everyone, as happened with those two.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

At the end of chapter 2 Paul showed Timothy how a servant of the Lord should treat those misled by false teaching – with gentleness and patience, in the hope that God will grant them repentance (2:24–26). But at the start of chapter 3 Paul warns him not to be naive about the spiritual climate in which he ministers. The "last days" – which in the New Testament means the whole period between Christ's first coming and his return – are marked not by a gradual moral improvement of humanity, but by spiritual storms and moral decay that will penetrate even the visible church.

What makes this passage so shocking is that Paul's list of eighteen sins in verses 2 to 4 is not simply a description of the pagan world out there. Verse 5 makes it crystal clear: they are people "having an outward form of godliness". This describes a spiritually decayed religion – people who outwardly take part in church life and speak religious language, but whose hearts have never been changed by the regenerating power of the Holy Spirit.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text unfolds a searching diagnosis of this moral and spiritual decay:

- **"Difficult times" (*kairoi chalepoi* – καιροὶ χαλεποί, v. 1):** Where our translation says that "difficult times will come", the Greek uses the word *kairoi* (which points to seasons or periods rather than mere clock time) together with the adjective *chalepos*. This word occurs in only one other place in the New Testament: Matthew 8:28, where it describes the two demon-possessed men of Gadara who were so "violent and dangerous" that no one could pass along that road. The last days will therefore be marked by fierce, dangerous and threatening seasons for those who hold on to the truth.
- **The fourfold twisted love (vv. 2 and 4):** See how masterfully Paul frames this catalogue of sins with compounds of the Greek root *philos* (love, affection). The list begins with:
  1. *Philautoi* – φίλαυτοι: "lovers of themselves" – the self-centred person who puts himself on the throne of the universe.
  2. *Philargyroi* – φιλάργυροι: "lovers of money", literally lovers of silver – when you worship yourself, money becomes the means of building your own kingdom. And the list ends in verse 4 with the inevitable climax:
  3. *Philēdonoi* – φιλήδονοι: lovers of sensual pleasure (from which we get the word *hedonism*) –

4. *Mallon ē philotheoi* – μᾶλλον ἢ φιλόθεοι: "rather than lovers of God". Paul shows here that the root of all human evil is a disorder of our love. As soon as love of self (*philautia*) displaces love of God (*philotheia*), the whole of society collapses. (In between, in verse 3, stands one more *phil-* word, but in negated form: *aphilagathoi* – ἀφιλάγαθοι, "haters of what is good", literally without love for the good.)

- **"Heartless, irreconcilable" (*astorgoi, aspondoi* – ἄστοργοι, ἄσπονδοι, v. 3):** Between these twisted loves lie the ruins of human relationships. People become *astorgoi* ("heartless" – without *storgē*, that innate, instinctive family bond between parents and children) and *aspondoi* ("irreconcilable" – literally people who refuse to make a peace treaty or truce; they nurse grudges and are always looking for conflict).
- **"Having an outward form of godliness but denying its power" (*morphōsin eusebeias … tēn de dynamin autēs ērnēmenoi* – μόρφωσιν εὐσεβείας … τὴν δὲ δύναμιν αὐτῆς ἠρνημένοι, v. 5):** They have a *morphōsis* (outward form, shell or appearance) of godliness, but they have denied its *dynamis* ("power"). They attend meetings, pray in public and debate theology, but their lives show zero per cent of the Holy Spirit's power that puts sin to death and forms the image of Christ. Paul's command to Timothy is radical: *apotrepou* (ἀποτρέπου) – "Turn away from such people!" (Turn your back on their influence.)
- **"Always learning" (*pantote manthanonta* – πάντοτε μανθάνοντα, vv. 6–7):** These false teachers especially target spiritually unstable people in their homes – those weighed down by a load of unconfessed guilt and tossed about by all kinds of new desires. Paul uses the diminutive *gynaikaria* (γυναικάρια, "weak women") here: it is a judgment on these particular people who let themselves be taken in, not on women in general. The result is that they are "always learning and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth". They are addicted to spiritual curiosity and new teachings, but never arrive at the true, saving knowledge of Christ.

- **Jannes and Jambres (*Iannēs kai Iambrēs* –Ἰάννης καὶἸαμβρῆς, vv. 8–9):** According to Jewish tradition, Jannes and Jambres were the two chief magicians at Pharaoh's court who opposed Moses when he was to lead God's people out of Egypt (Exodus 7:11, 22). How did they oppose Moses? Not by openly denying that supernatural power exists, but by **imitating** Moses' miracles with their own occult sorcery (they too turned their staffs into snakes and water into blood). False religion always works by imitation! But just as the powerlessness and "folly" (*anoia* – ἄνοια) of Jannes and Jambres were exposed before all Egypt when they themselves were struck by the plague of boils (Exodus 9:11), so God will in the end unmask the empty shell of every false teacher before everyone.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Self-love is the fountain of social decay.** While our modern culture proclaims that "loving yourself first" is the key to human healing, Scripture declares that *philautia* (self-love) is the poisoned spring from which ingratitude, broken families and cruelty flow.
2. **Genuine Christianity is a supernatural power, not an outward shell.** The gospel is the *dynamis* of God (Romans 1:16). If someone's faith does not change him from a lover of self into a lover of God, his religion is an empty shell.
3. **Spiritual information without repentance bears no fruit.** Always reading new books, listening to sermons and piling up theological knowledge while clinging to your pet sins brings you not one step closer to the truth.
4. **God's truth will outlast every counterfeit.** Counterfeit religion may look impressive for a season, but before the judgment seat of God's Word and of time its folly will be revealed.

Living It Out

When we read 2 Timothy 3:1–5 today, it does not feel like an ancient document from two thousand years ago; it reads like this morning's headlines and the content of our social media feeds.

We live in the golden age of *philautia* – the cult of the self. Our society has raised "self-love", "self-fulfilment" and the pursuit of personal pleasure (*philēdonia*) to the highest virtues. And exactly as Paul foretold, we are reaping the bitter fruit today: an epidemic of loneliness, children living in rebellion against their parents, a consumer mentality that is grateful for nothing, the breakdown of natural family love, and a merciless "cancel culture" that is *aspondos* – irreconcilable and without forgiveness.

Yet the sharpest question of this text is aimed not at the world out there, but at **us who sit in the pews**. It is frighteningly easy to keep up a *morphōsis* – a neat outer shell – of godliness. You can learn the right Christian vocabulary, take your seat in the service on Sundays and even be involved in church activities, while in private you deny the *dynamis* – the sanctifying power – of the gospel by still living for yourself, your own comfort and your own pleasure.

Notice too the warning of verse 7: people "always learning and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth". In our digital age we have access to more Bible studies, podcasts, sermons and theological articles than any generation before us. But knowledge that stays in the head and never sinks down into a broken, obedient heart that turns away from sin makes us spiritually immune to real change. Don't be content with the shell of religion or with the imitation of a Jannes and Jambres – seek the living power of the risen Christ, who makes your heart new from the inside!

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- If I look honestly at how I spend my time, my money and my free hours, what does my life testify to most strongly: that I am a lover of myself and of pleasure, or a sincere lover of God (*philotheos*)?

- Is there any area of my life where I am currently content with an outward form of godliness before people, while resisting the transforming power of the Holy Spirit to set me free from a specific sin?
- Do I live out in practical obedience the truth I have already learned from God's Word, or do I merely collect knowledge without it changing my character?

Prayer

> *Holy and Almighty God, you test hearts and minds and see through every human mask. Today I bow before your Word in deep earnest. As I read this list of sins, I had to admit with shame how easily the spirit of this age clings to my own heart as well. Forgive me, Lord, for the deep-rooted self-love, the ingratitude and the pursuit of my own comfort and pleasure that so often try to take your rightful place on the throne of my heart.*
>
> *Lord, guard my soul from the terrible deception of an empty religion of mere form! I do not want only an outward form of godliness that impresses people while my heart stays cold and unchanged. Let the resurrection power of Jesus Christ, through your Holy Spirit, reach into every corner of my life – break my pride, heal my relationships, make me a reconciler, and fill me with a burning, undivided love for you alone.*
>
> *Keep me, too, from being only a hearer of the Word who is always learning but never changes. Grant that every truth I receive from your Scripture may draw me closer to the living person of Jesus. Keep me standing in these difficult and dangerous times, until every lie is exposed and your truth triumphs in full glory. In the mighty name of Jesus Christ, our Lord and Redeemer. Amen.*

DAY 7

Persevere in the Holy, God-Breathed Scriptures

SCRIPTURE

2 Timothy 3:10–17

10 You, however, have closely followed my teaching, my way of life, my
purpose, my faith, my patience, my love, my endurance, 11 my persecu-
tions and my sufferings, the things that happened to me in Antioch, in
Iconium and in Lystra. What persecutions I bore! And the Lord rescued
me from all of them. 12 Indeed, all who want to live in godliness in
Christ Jesus will be persecuted. 13 But evil people and impostors will go
from bad to worse, deceiving and being deceived. 14 But you, remain in
what you have learned and have become convinced of, knowing from
whom you learned it, 15 and that from childhood you have known the sa-
cred writings, which can give you the wisdom that leads to salvation
through faith in Christ Jesus. 16 All Scripture is God-breathed and useful
for teaching, for reproof, for correction, for training in righteousness,
17 so that the man of God may be fully capable, equipped for every good
work.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In the first nine verses of chapter 3, Paul has unmasked the moral decay and the empty, outward religion of the last days. Now, in verse 10, he makes another sharp turn: "*You, however* ..." (*Sy de*). Over against the false teachers, who worm their way into households and display only an outward form of godliness, Paul sets his own transparent life – and the unshakeable authority of Holy Scripture.

Why does Paul mention in verse 11 the persecutions in **Antioch, Iconium and Lystra** in particular (see Acts 13–14)? Because Lystra was very probably Timothy's own home town (Acts 16:1)! As a young boy, Timothy may well have seen with his own eyes how the furious crowd stoned Paul in Lystra, dragged his bloodied body out of the city like a corpse and left him there. And he saw Paul get up, shake off the dust, walk straight back into the city, and later return to Lystra on his second missionary journey. So Timothy knew that Paul was no comfortable "armchair theologian". He bore the scars of everything he proclaimed.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Here the Greek text unfolds one of the most important passages in the whole New Testament on discipleship and the nature of the Bible:

- **"You, however, have closely followed my teaching" (*parēkolouthēsas* – παρηκολούθησας, v. 10):** This verb means to walk so closely beside someone that you put your feet in his footprints and study his life at close range. Timothy did not just listen to Paul's sermons; he watched at close quarters Paul's *agōgē* (way of life), his *prothesis* (purpose, his aim in life), his *makrothymia* (patience with difficult people) and his *hypomonē* (endurance under pressure).
- **Impostors and "remain" (*goētes* – γόητες / *mene* – μένε, vv. 13–14):** While everyone who wants to live in godliness (*eusebōs*) in Christ Jesus will meet opposition, evil people and "impostors" (*goētes* – literally sorcerers or charlatans who bewitch people with charming spells) "will go from bad to worse". They deceive others but in the end become victims of their own lies. Against their restless wandering, Paul gives Timothy one powerful anchor word in verse 14: *mene* – "Remain!" Do not chase after every new spiritual fad; stay rooted in the reliable truth in which you have been taught.
- **From childhood and the sacred writings (*apo brephous* – ἀπὸ βρέφους / *hiera grammata* – ἱερὰ γράμματα, v. 15):** Timothy had known the "sacred writings" *apo brephous* – literally since he was a

nursing infant or a very small child on the lap of his mother Eunice and his grandmother Lois! But notice what Scripture does: the Old Testament writings did not bring salvation by themselves through mere law-keeping; they *"can give you the wisdom that leads to salvation through faith in Christ Jesus"*. The whole Old Testament points like a signpost straight to the person and the saving work of Jesus on the cross (see Luke 24:27).

- **"All Scripture is God-breathed" (*pasa graphē theopneustos* – πᾶσα γραφὴ θεόπνευστος, v. 16):** The Greek word *theopneustos* (*theos* = God; *pneō* = to breathe out) occurs only here in the New Testament. It means literally that Scripture has been **"breathed out by God"**. This does not mean that God merely blessed human writers' existing books after the fact, or "inspired" them the way a poet is inspired. The words of Scripture are the direct product of God's own creative breath of life (see Psalm 33:6). When Scripture speaks, God himself speaks! (Grammatically, the reading "Every God-breathed Scripture is also useful …" is also possible; our translation follows the more common reading.)
- **The fourfold work of the Word (v. 16):** Because Scripture is God's breath, it is fully useful (*ōphelimos*) for four things that cover the whole journey of our lives:
  1. *Didaskalia* (teaching): It shows us **what is right** (sound teaching and truth).
  2. *Elegmos* (reproof): It shows us **what is not right** (it exposes our sin and false teaching).
  3. *Epanorthōsis* (correction): The word means to set something upright again or restore it – like setting a broken bone straight or lifting a fallen pillar upright again. It shows us **how to get right**.
  4. *Paideian tēn en dikaiosynē* (training in righteousness): This refers to the ongoing upbringing and discipline of a child. It shows us **how to stay right**.

- **"Fully capable, equipped for every good work" (*artios* – ἄρτιος / *exērtismenos* – ἐξηρτισμένος, v. 17):** The purpose of Scripture is that the "man of God" may be *artios* (competent, mature and fit for his task) and *exērtismenos* – a word that could also be used of a ship or a wagon fully fitted out for a long journey. The Bible is entirely sufficient for every spiritual storm and for every good work to which God calls us.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **True mentoring lives the gospel out in the open.** The most powerful passing on of faith happens when younger believers not only hear our words but also see how we love, forgive and are carried through suffering.
2. **Opposition is the normal temperature of a life of godliness in a fallen world.** When you live out the character of Jesus, it inevitably collides with the darkness of the world (v. 12) – but the Lord rescues his children and carries them through every fiery furnace (v. 11).
3. **The Bible's authority rests on its divine origin (*theopneustos*).** Because all Scripture is breathed out by God, it stands above all human opinions, cultural shifts and philosophical criticism.
4. **Scripture is sufficient.** We need no extra-biblical revelations, worldly psychological crutches or "new truths" to be spiritually mature and fully equipped for God's service.

Living It Out

In a world where everything keeps shifting and moral landmarks are moved overnight, 2 Timothy 3:10–17 gives us an unshakeable rock to stand on.

First, look at **the power of an open life (vv. 10–11)** and **early faith formation (v. 15)**. If you are a parent, grandparent or spiritual leader, don't just tell the children and young people in your life about the Bible; let them see how your faith works when it hurts. Timothy's faith was so strong be-

cause he had seen Paul get up after a stoning in Lystra, and because his mother and grandmother had impressed the Word on him from the time he was a baby. It is never too early to sow the seed of God's Word in a little child's heart – that seed has the power to make them wise for eternity through faith in Jesus!

Second, look at our relationship with the Bible in verses 16 and 17. Many believers confess with their lips that the Bible is the Word of God, yet in practice we treat it as if it were not enough. We read a quick devotional to soothe our conscience, but when we face real crises we look for our answers in the wisdom of the world.

Let the fourfold surgery of the *theopneustos* Word do its full work in your life today:

- Let Scripture **teach** you (fill your mind with who God is).
- Don't close your Bible when it **reproves** you and puts its finger on a hidden sin or a wrong attitude.
- Welcome its **correction** (*epanorthōsis*) – God never exposes your sin to destroy you, but to set your broken life straight and lift you up again!
- Submit daily to its **training in righteousness**, so that like a fully equipped ship you will be ready for every good work God brings across your path today.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- If someone watched my daily life as closely as Timothy watched Paul's – my goals, my patience under pressure and my response to hardship – would it draw them closer to Christ?
- Do I expect the Christian life always to be comfortable and free of opposition, or am I willing to bear the misunderstanding and rejection of the world for the sake of a life of godliness in Christ?

- Do I let the "God-breathed" Scripture not only comfort me but also *reprove* me and *bend me straight* where my life has drifted from God's will?

Prayer

> *Eternal and Almighty God, by your living breath you created the universe, and you have breathed out your holy Word for us.*
>
> *I bow before you today in deep gratitude. Thank you that you have not left us groping in the dark, wondering who you are and how we can be saved. Thank you for the precious treasure of Holy Scripture, which has opened my eyes to the salvation that is found in Jesus Christ alone.*
>
> *Lord, forgive me for every time I have taken your Word for granted, or have been slow to sit at your feet. Forgive me too where I have drawn back when your Word exposed my sin and reproved me. Make my heart soft and teachable today. Speak by your Spirit to my inmost being: teach me your truth, reprove me where I stray, set me upright where I have fallen, and train me daily in your righteousness.*
>
> *Give me the grace to remain in what I have learned from your Word, even when deceit and godlessness increase in the world and when it costs me something to live in godliness. Equip me fully through your sufficient Word for every good work to which you call me today.*
>
> *In the name of Jesus Christ, the Word of God made flesh. Amen.*

DAY 8

Proclaim the Word and Finish the Race

SCRIPTURE

2 Timothy 4:1–8

[1] I solemnly charge you before God and Christ Jesus, who is going to
judge the living and the dead, and by his appearing and his kingdom:
[2] proclaim the word; keep at it whether the time is right or not; reprove,
rebuke, encourage, with all patience and teaching. [3] For the time will
come when people will not put up with sound teaching, but, following
their own desires, will pile up teachers for themselves because their
ears itch, [4] and they will turn their ears away from the truth and wander
off to myths. [5] But you, be sober-minded in everything, endure hard-
ship, do the work of an evangelist, carry out your service fully.

[6] For already I am being poured out as a drink offering, and the time for
my departure is here. [7] I have fought the good fight, I have run the race
to the end, I have kept the faith. [8] What remains is this: the crown of
righteousness is stored up for me, which the Lord, the righteous judge,
will give me on that day – and not to me only, but to all who have loved
his appearing.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

These eight verses form the dramatic and emotional climax of Paul's whole apostolic ministry. At the end of chapter 3, Paul laid the unshakeable foundation that all Scripture is breathed out by God (*theopneustos*) and fully sufficient (3:16–17). Now, without any break (there were, after all, no chapter divisions in the original manuscript), he links that teaching about the nature of Scripture directly to the most solemn charge in the letter: because Scripture is God's living voice, Timothy must **proclaim** it.

Paul writes knowing that his earthly time has run out. In Rome death awaits him – according to early church tradition, by the executioner's sword. But before he leaves the stage of this world, he summons Timothy, as it were, into the heavenly courtroom – into the presence of God and Christ Jesus, the coming Judge and King – to take over from him the torch of proclaiming the Word without compromise.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek text opens a treasure chest of images from the courtroom, the altar, the harbour and the racetrack:

- **"Proclaim the word" (*kēryxon ton logon* – κήρυξον τὸν λόγον, v. 2):** The verb *kēryssō* comes from *kēryx* – the imperial herald or town crier of the ancient world. A herald did not stand up in the town square to share his own personal philosophy or to chair a panel discussion; with a loud, authoritative voice he announced the King's decree. His only duty was absolute faithfulness to the message of the one who sent him.
- **"Whether the time is right or not" (*eukairōs akairōs* – εὐκαίρως ἀκαίρως, v. 2):** He is to keep at it (*epistēthi* – "stand ready", like a sentry at his post) "whether the time is right or not". That means bringing the Word when the season is favourable and also when it is inconvenient, unwelcome or dangerous – whether it suits the preacher and whether the hearers welcome it or not.
- **"Because their ears itch" (*knēthomenoi tēn akoēn* – κνηθόμενοι τὴν ἀκοήν, v. 3):** Why is this urgency needed? Because seasons will come when people within the visible church "will not put up with sound teaching" (*ouk anexontai*). The Greek *knēthō* literally describes an itchy spot that wants to be scratched or tickled. Instead of submitting their lives to God's Word, they "pile up teachers for themselves" (*episōreusousin* – to heap up in a pile) who will cater to their sinful desires and soothe their consciences without ever addressing their sin.

- **"Be sober-minded" and "carry out your service fully" (*nēphe* – νῆφε / *plērophorēson* – πληροφόρησον, v. 5):** In the midst of the culture's spiritual drunkenness, Timothy is to be "sober-minded in everything" (*nēphō* – clear-headed, calm and focused) and to carry out his service fully (*plērophoreō* – to finish a task down to the last drop).
- **The drink offering and the departure (*spendomai* – σπένδομαι / *kairos tēs analyseōs* – καιρὸς τῆς ἀναλύσεως, v. 6):** Here Paul gives us two of the most beautiful images for a believer's death in the whole Bible:
  1. *The drink offering*: "For already I am being poured out as a drink offering." In the Old Testament sacrificial service (Numbers 15:1–10) and in the ancient world, the drink offering was a cup of precious wine poured out with the sacrifice – according to later Jewish sources at the foot of the altar, among the Greeks often over the sacrifice itself. Together with the offering it was "a pleasing aroma to the Lord" (Numbers 15:10). Paul does not see his coming execution as a tragic waste of his life, but as the final offering of worship poured out on God's altar!
  2. *Casting off the ropes*: "... and the time for my departure is here." The noun *analysis* was used of a traveller pulling up his tent pegs to go home, and of a ship in harbour whose heavy mooring ropes are loosed from the quay so that it can sail out to the open sea. For a child of God, death is not a blind sinking into the dark, but the loosing of earthly ropes to sail into the eternal harbour.
- **The threefold look back and the crown (vv. 7–8):** With three verbs in the Greek perfect tense (which marks a completed action with lasting results), Paul looks back on his life: *"I have fought the good fight, I have run the race to the end, I have kept the faith"* (*ton kalon agōna ēgōnismai, ton dromon tetelēka, tēn pistin tetērēka*). And then he looks ahead: in Rome an unjust court of Nero's empire will soon find him guilty, but in heaven *"the righteous judge"* is waiting with *"the crown of righteousness"*

(*stephanos* – the victor's wreath). This crown is not meant for apostles only, but for "*all who have loved his appearing*" (*tois ēgapēkosi tēn epiphaneian autou*) – every believer who longs for Christ's return.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **We live and serve before the eyes of the coming King.** The strongest antidote to the fear of people and to compromise is knowing that one day we will give account to Jesus Christ, who at his appearing will judge the living and the dead.
2. **True ministry of the Word comforts the grieving and wakes up the comfortable.** Preaching and bearing witness faithfully means that with the truth we reprove, rebuke and encourage with endless patience (*makrothymia*), whether the culture wants to hear it or not.
3. **Ear-tickling is the forerunner of spiritual ruin.** As soon as people make their own desires the standard and turn their ears away from the truth, they fall prey to absurd myths.
4. **A life poured out for Christ ends in eternal triumph.** The world sees an old man laying his head on the executioner's block; heaven sees a victor crossing the finish line to be crowned by the hand of his King.

Living It Out

This passage challenges us to the very marrow of our spiritual lives: **How do we listen to the Word – and how will we finish our race?**

First, look at the diagnosis in verses 3 and 4: people gather teachers "because their ears itch". In the first century, people had to travel far to find a false teacher who would soothe their conscience. Today, with the internet and social media, anyone can "pile up" thousands of voices on a screen within seconds, all saying exactly what they want to hear. If you want to keep living in a particular sin, or if you are only looking for a message that

strokes your ego and promises you earthly prosperity without ever speaking of repentance, self-denial and the cross, you will find plenty of preachers to scratch your ears.

But a doctor who only tells you how well you look while a deadly tumour grows in your body does not love you! We should thank God every time the preaching of his Word reproves and rebukes us – when the Holy Spirit makes us uncomfortable about our sin – because that is the operating theatre where God saves our souls and makes them whole.

Second, look at Paul's testimony at the end of his road (vv. 6–8). Each of our own *analysis* – the day our mooring ropes on this earth are loosed – is drawing nearer. We do not know whether we have thirty years or thirty hours left. The most important question on your deathbed will not be how much money you made, how popular you were or how comfortable your life was. The only question that will matter then is whether you can say with Paul: **I stayed in the arena, I ran my lane all the way to the white line, and I held on to the treasure of the faith!**

And how do you manage to finish like that? Verse 8 gives the secret: by belonging to *"all who have loved his appearing"*. When your heart is full of longing for the day you will see Jesus face to face, the cheap little crowns of this world fade – and you receive the strength to pour out your life today like a drink offering to his glory.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- When I read the Bible and listen to sermons, am I only looking for messages that "tickle my ears" and make me feel good – or do I welcome the Word also when it reproves and rebukes me?
- Do I share the truth of the gospel with the people around me "whether the time is right or not", with patient love – or do I fall silent as soon as the opportunity feels uncomfortable?

- If my earthly mooring ropes were loosed today, could I testify with confidence that I have poured out my life as a thank offering for Christ and that I am looking forward with joy to his appearing?

Prayer

Lord Jesus Christ, living King and righteous Judge, before whose eyes my whole life lies open and bare:

I bow before you today in holy reverence. When I think of the day of your glorious appearing and your kingdom, the noise and the emptiness of this world fade away. Keep my heart from ever growing tired of the pure, sound teaching of your Word. Heal me of ears that itch and only want to be soothed; give me a hunger for the whole truth – even when your Word reproves me, breaks my pride and calls me to repentance.

Lord, make me spiritually sober and awake in a world intoxicated by myths and lies. Give me the courage to bear witness to your grace whether the time is right or not, and to carry out fully, to the last drop, the calling you have placed on my life.

I thank you for the victorious testimony of your servant Paul. Teach me not to hold my life back stingily for myself, but to pour it out every day on your altar like a fragrant drink offering of love and service. Give me the grace to fight the good fight, to run my race to the end and to keep the faith until one day the mooring ropes are loosed and I see your face. I love your appearing, O Lord – come soon!

In your mighty and royal name. Amen.

DAY 9

Alone in the Dungeon, but the Lord Stands by Me

SCRIPTURE

2 Timothy 4:9–22

9 Make every effort to come to me soon. 10 For Demas has abandoned me,
because he loved this present age, and has gone to Thessalonica;
Crescens has gone to Galatia, Titus to Dalmatia. 11 Only Luke is with me.
Pick up Mark and bring him along, for he is useful to me for service. 12 I
have sent Tychicus to Ephesus. 13 When you come, bring the cloak that I
left with Carpus in Troas, and the books, especially the parchments.
14 Alexander the metalworker did me much harm – the Lord will repay
him according to his works. 15 You too must be on your guard against
him, for he strongly opposed our words.

16 At my first defence no one stood by me, but all abandoned me – may it
not be counted against them! 17 But the Lord stood by me and gave me
strength, so that through me the proclamation might be fully carried
out and all the nations might hear it; and I was rescued from the mouth
of the lion. 18 The Lord will rescue me from every evil deed and will save
me for his heavenly kingdom. To him be the glory for ever and ever.
Amen.

19 Greet Prisca and Aquila and the household of Onesiphorus. 20 Erastus
stayed in Corinth, and I left Trophimus sick in Miletus. 21 Make every ef-
fort to come before winter. Eubulus greets you, as do Pudens and Linus
and Claudia and all the brothers and sisters.

22 The Lord be with your spirit. Grace be with you all.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In these moving closing verses we hear the very last recorded words from the pen of the apostle Paul before his earthly life was ended – according to tradition, by the sword of Rome. After the majestic victory song of verses 6 to 8, where he spoke of his finished race and the crown of righteousness waiting for him, the tone now drops to the raw, human reality of his imprisonment in Rome.

It was probably around AD 66 or 67, and winter was approaching (v. 21). Once the autumn storms began to blow across the Mediterranean, most shipping stopped until spring; if Timothy could not leave Ephesus before winter, he would probably never see Paul alive again. Paul sits in chains in prison – according to tradition in a cold, damp stone dungeon. He is physically chilled and asks for his heavy cloak; he is intellectually and spiritually hungry for his books and parchments; and he feels the deep pain of human abandonment. While some co-workers (such as Crescens, Titus and Tychicus) have been sent out on legitimate missions and only Luke, the faithful physician, has stayed with him, his heart is bruised by betrayal and loneliness. Yet nowhere does the glory of Christ shine more brightly than in this very abandonment.

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The original Greek text paints an unforgettable portrait of human frailty and divine faithfulness:

- **"For Demas has abandoned me, because he loved this present age" (*Dēmas gar me egkatelipen agapēsas ton nyn aiōna* – Δημᾶς γάρ με ἐγκατέλιπεν ἀγαπήσας τὸν νῦν αἰῶνα, v. 10):** In Paul's earlier letters (Philemon 24; Colossians 4:14) Demas is mentioned with honour as a valued co-worker at Paul's side. But the Greek verb *egkataleipō* means to leave someone in the lurch in a crisis or on the battlefield and run away. Why? Notice the sharp contrast with verse 8: while faithful be-

lievers *have loved* Christ's future *appearing* (*ēgapēkosi*), Demas *loved this present age* (*agapēsas*). When the price of discipleship became too high, he chose earthly comfort and safety over the cross.

- **"Pick up Mark ... for he is useful to me" (*Markon analabōn age ... euchrēstos* – Μᾶρκον ἀναλαβὼν ἄγε ... εὔχρηστος, v. 11):** Right after the heartache over Demas comes one of the most beautiful moments of grace in the New Testament: "*Pick up Mark and bring him along, for he is useful to me for service*." Years earlier, on the first missionary journey, a young and frightened John Mark had deserted Paul and Barnabas in Pamphylia (Acts 13:13), which later led to a sharp split between Paul and Barnabas (Acts 15:37–39). But under the patient mentoring of Barnabas and Peter, Mark grew. Now Paul calls him *euchrēstos* – exactly the word he used in 2 Timothy 2:21 for a purified "vessel meant for honour", "useful to the master"! Demas started strong and finished badly; Mark stumbled, but by grace finished strong.
- **The cloak, the books and the parchments (*ton phailonēn ... ta biblia, malista tas membranas* – τὸν φαιλόνην ... τὰ βιβλία, μάλιστα τὰς μεμβράνας, v. 13):** The *phailonēs* ("cloak") was a thick, circular woollen cape with an opening for the head, which protected travellers against icy rain and winter cold. Along with it the old apostle asks for his *biblia* (scrolls, probably of papyrus) and especially the *membranas* – costly, durable sheets of parchment (prepared animal skin). What exactly was written on them we do not know – perhaps notebooks, perhaps parts of the Old Testament. Even at the end of his life, as a celebrated apostle about to enter heaven, Paul very probably never stops studying the Scriptures.
- **The first defence and "the Lord stood by me" (*En tē prōtē mou apologia* – Ἐν τῇ πρώτῃ μου ἀπολογίᾳ / *ho de kyrios moi parestē* – ὁ δὲ κύριός μοι παρέστη, vv. 16–17):** In the Roman legal system the *prōtē apologia* ("first defence") was probably the preliminary hearing (*prima actio*) before the court to establish the charges. Perhaps Alexander the metalworker acted as a witness or accuser against Paul (v. 14) – and Paul

does not take revenge himself but leaves the matter with God: *"the Lord will repay him according to his works"*. The atmosphere in Rome was so dangerous that no one had the courage to stand beside Paul in the courtroom as a character witness. All had abandoned him. But like Jesus on the cross (Luke 23:34) and Stephen under the stones (Acts 7:60), Paul prays without any bitterness: *"may it not be counted against them!"* And then comes the glorious turn: **"But the Lord stood by me!"** The verb *paristēmi* means to come and stand right beside someone – in a courtroom, like an advocate and defender beside the accused. Christ strengthened Paul inwardly (*enedynamōsen*), so that before the highest court in the world he could proclaim the gospel to the Roman authorities, and he was for the time being "rescued from the mouth of the lion" – an Old Testament image from Psalm 22:21 (Hebrew 22:22) and Daniel 6 for mortal danger, or for Nero's immediate death sentence.

- **"The Lord will rescue me ... and will save me for his heavenly kingdom" (*rhysetai me ... kai sōsei eis tēn basileian autou tēn epouranion* – ῥύσεταί με ... καὶ σώσει εἰς τὴν βασιλείαν αὐτοῦ τὴν ἐπουράνιον, v. 18):** Paul looks with perfect peace towards the final trial and the sword that awaits him. Even if Rome cuts off his head, he declares that the Lord will rescue him "from every evil deed" (keep him from falling into sin or denying his faith under pressure) and bring him safely through and save him (sōzō) right into his heavenly kingdom!

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Where our love lies determines how we finish.** A heart that secretly stays in love with "this present age" (like Demas) will in the end drop out when the way of the cross gets hard; only love for Christ and his kingdom keeps us standing to the end.
2. **Past failure is never final with God.** The story of Mark proves that God can fully restore broken and fallen servants who repent and make them *euchrēstos* (highly useful) for his kingdom.

3. **Spiritual maturity is marked by a forgiving spirit and a hunger for the Word.** Even in his darkest hour Paul does not nurse grudges against friends who deserted him, and his soul keeps thirsting for the parchments of God's Word.
4. **Christ's presence is enough when every human support falls away.** People may leave you, and even believing friends may sometimes, like Trophimus, be left behind sick (v. 20) – but the living Lord personally stands beside his child in the fiery furnace and carries him safely across the threshold of death into eternal glory.

Living It Out

At the end of this unforgettable letter we stand with Paul in the half-light of his Roman cell, and we find that his last words speak deeply to our own hearts.

First, look at the two names **Demas and Mark** (vv. 10–11). Each of our lives is moving in one of these two directions. It does not matter how well you began your spiritual race or how many years you have been in church: if you allow love for this present age – its status, its money, its pleasure and its human approval – to conquer your heart, you are in danger of becoming a Demas who drops out when sacrifice is required. But perhaps you read these words today and feel like Mark: you look back on a time in your life when you let the Lord or other people down, when you ran away out of fear, and you think you have been thrown on the spiritual scrap heap for good. Hear the gospel today: God is the God of second chances! If you return to him, his grace makes you *euchrēstos* again – useful and precious in his service.

Second, look at Paul's request for his **cloak and the parchments** (v. 13), and his remark about **Trophimus, whom he left sick in Miletus** (v. 20). This reminds us of the honest realism of biblical faith. Even the greatest apostle, through whom God had once done miracles, needed a warm coat in his cold prison and could not heal every sick co-worker on demand.

True faith is not a denial of physical cold, pain or illness; it is a deep resting in God's sovereign will in the midst of our earthly frailty – while we keep our hearts warm at the fire of Scripture ("the parchments").

Finally, take verses 16 to 18 with you into every lonely night that may still await you on life's road. There are times in a person's life – in a hospital room, in a divorce court, at an open grave, or when you have to stand up for the truth alone – when even those closest to you cannot or will not stand by you. Do not let human disappointment poison your heart with bitterness; pray with Paul: *"may it not be counted against them!"* And then look up and see who is standing right beside you: **The Lord stands by you!** And even when the last earthly storm breaks, he will save you – not necessarily *from* physical death, but *through* death into his safe, heavenly kingdom.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Is there any secret "Demas love" in my heart for the things of this present age that is slowly cooling my devotion to Christ – or am I letting God restore me, like Mark, to usefulness after my failures?
- Am I holding on to any grudge or unforgiveness towards people or fellow believers who let me down and left me alone in a time of need?
- Have I known the deep, personal experience of the Lord Jesus himself coming to stand beside me and filling me with his strength when every human support gives way?

Prayer

> *Lord Jesus Christ, my faithful Friend, my Advocate and my eternal King:*
>
> *with a full and grateful heart I bow before you today at the end of this precious letter. Thank you for the life and the last testimony of your servant Paul. When I look at that cold dungeon in Rome, I see that your grace is enough for the darkest night and that your light can never be put out by human evil.*

Lord, guard my heart from the tragedy of Demas. Do not let the glittering temptations of this present age ever steal my love for you. And where in the past, like Mark, I have stumbled, been afraid or failed, I thank you that you do not throw me away, but cleanse me through your blood and make me useful again for your kingdom. Give me, right into old age, an unquenchable hunger for the parchments of your Word.

Today I choose to release and forgive everyone who has hurt me or left me in the lurch in my hour of need; do not count it against them, Lord. For I know that I am never truly alone: you stand by me! You give me strength when my own legs give way beneath me. I trust you today with my life and with my dying, in the firm certainty that you will rescue me from every evil deed and one day bring me safely into your heavenly kingdom.

To you be all praise, honour and glory, from now on and for ever and ever! May your grace be with my spirit every day. Amen.

The whole of Second Timothy

The complete text of Paul's second letter to Timothy in the translation used in these devotionals.

Chapter 1

[1] Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus through the will of God, in keeping with the promise of the life that is in Christ Jesus, [2] to Timothy, my beloved child: grace, mercy and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord.

[3] I am grateful to God, whom I serve with a clear conscience as my forefathers did, when I remember you without ceasing in my prayers, night and day. [4] I long to see you – I remember your tears – so that I may be filled with joy, [5] for I have been reminded of the sincere faith that is in you, a faith that lived first in your grandmother Lois and in your mother Eunice, and I am convinced that it lives in you as well. [6] For this reason I remind you to rekindle the gift of God that is in you through the laying on of my hands. [7] For God did not give us a spirit of cowardice, but of power and of love and of self-control.

[8] Do not be ashamed, then, of the testimony about our Lord or of me, his prisoner; rather, share in hardship for the gospel, in the power of God, [9] who saved us and called us with a holy calling, not on the basis of our works but on the basis of his own purpose and grace, which was given to us in Christ Jesus before eternal ages, [10] but has now been revealed through the appearing of our Saviour Jesus Christ, who broke the power of death and brought life and imperishability to light through the gospel, [11] for which I was appointed a herald and an apostle and a teacher. [12] That is why I am suffering these things too; but I am not ashamed, for I know whom I have believed, and I am convinced that he is able to guard my entrusted deposit until that day. [13] Hold to the example of sound words that you heard from me, in the faith and love that are in Christ Jesus. [14] Guard the precious thing that has been entrusted to you, through the Holy Spirit who lives in us.

[15] You know that all who are in the province of Asia have turned away from me, among them Phygelus and Hermogenes. [16] May the Lord grant mercy to the household of Onesiphorus, for he often refreshed me and was not

ashamed of my chain. [17] On the contrary, when he came to Rome, he searched hard for me and found me – [18] may the Lord grant him to find mercy from the Lord on that day! – and you know better than I do how much he served in Ephesus.

Chapter 2

[1] You then, my child, be strengthened by the grace that is in Christ Jesus.
[2] And the things you heard from me through many witnesses – entrust these to faithful people who will be competent to teach others too. [3] Share in hardship as a good soldier of Christ Jesus. [4] No one serving as a soldier gets entangled in the affairs of everyday life, since he wants to please the one who enlisted him. [5] Likewise, anyone who competes as an athlete is not crowned unless he competes according to the rules. [6] The farmer who works hard ought to be the first to receive a share of the crops. [7] Think about what I am saying, for the Lord will give you understanding in everything.

[8] Remember Jesus Christ, raised from the dead, descended from David, according to my gospel. [9] For this gospel I am enduring hardship, even to the point of being chained like a criminal. But the word of God is not chained.
[10] That is why I endure all things for the sake of the chosen, so that they too may obtain the salvation that is in Christ Jesus, with eternal glory. [11] This is a trustworthy saying:

For if we died with him,
we will also live with him;
[12] if we endure,
we will also reign with him;
if we will deny him,
he also will deny us;
[13] if we are faithless,
he remains faithful –
for he cannot deny himself.

[14] Keep reminding them of these things, and solemnly charge them before the Lord not to fight about words; it is of no use and only ruins those who listen.
[15] Make every effort to present yourself to God as approved, a worker with nothing to be ashamed of, who handles the word of truth accurately. [16] But

avoid irreverent, empty chatter, for those who indulge in it will advance further and further into ungodliness, [17] and their talk will spread like gangrene. Among them are Hymenaeus and Philetus, [18] who have missed the mark concerning the truth by saying that the resurrection has already taken place, and they are overturning the faith of some. [19] Yet the solid foundation laid by God stands firm, and it bears this seal: "The Lord knows who are his," and: "Everyone who names the name of the Lord must turn away from wrongdoing."

[20] In a large house you find not only vessels of gold and silver, but also vessels of wood and clay – some meant for honour, others for dishonour. [21] So if anyone purifies himself from these, he will be a vessel meant for honour – consecrated, useful to the master, prepared for every good work. [22] Flee from the desires of youth, and pursue righteousness, faith, love and peace, together with those who call on the Lord out of a pure heart. [23] Refuse foolish and uninstructed controversies, knowing that they give rise to quarrels. [24] And a servant of the Lord must not quarrel, but be kind to everyone, able to teach, patient when wronged, [25] instructing with gentleness those who oppose him, in the hope that God may grant them repentance that leads to the knowledge of the truth, [26] and they will come to their senses and escape from the trap of the devil, having been taken captive by him for his will.

Chapter 3

[1] But understand this: in the last days difficult times will come. [2] For people will be lovers of themselves, lovers of money, boastful, arrogant, blasphemers, disobedient to their parents, ungrateful, unholy, [3] heartless, irreconcilable, slanderers, without self-restraint, brutal, haters of what is good, [4] treacherous, reckless, puffed up, lovers of pleasure rather than lovers of God, [5] having an outward form of godliness but denying its power. Turn away from such people! [6] For among them are those who worm their way into households and take captive weak women, who are weighed down with sins and driven by all kinds of desires, [7] always learning and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth. [8] Just as Jannes and Jambres opposed Moses, so these also oppose the truth: people corrupted in mind, who have failed the test regarding the faith. [9] But they will not get very far, for their folly will become plain to everyone, as happened with those two.

10 You, however, have closely followed my teaching, my way of life, my purpose, my faith, my patience, my love, my endurance, 11 my persecutions and my sufferings, the things that happened to me in Antioch, in Iconium and in Lystra. What persecutions I bore! And the Lord rescued me from all of them. 12 Indeed, all who want to live in godliness in Christ Jesus will be persecuted. 13 But evil people and impostors will go from bad to worse, deceiving and being deceived. 14 But you, remain in what you have learned and have become convinced of, knowing from whom you learned it, 15 and that from childhood you have known the sacred writings, which can give you the wisdom that leads to salvation through faith in Christ Jesus. 16 All Scripture is God-breathed and useful for teaching, for reproof, for correction, for training in righteousness, 17 so that the man of God may be fully capable, equipped for every good work.

Chapter 4

1 I solemnly charge you before God and Christ Jesus, who is going to judge the living and the dead, and by his appearing and his kingdom: 2 proclaim the word; keep at it whether the time is right or not; reprove, rebuke, encourage, with all patience and teaching. 3 For the time will come when people will not put up with sound teaching, but, following their own desires, will pile up teachers for themselves because their ears itch, 4 and they will turn their ears away from the truth and wander off to myths. 5 But you, be sober-minded in everything, endure hardship, do the work of an evangelist, carry out your service fully.

6 For already I am being poured out as a drink offering, and the time for my departure is here. 7 I have fought the good fight, I have run the race to the end, I have kept the faith. 8 What remains is this: the crown of righteousness is stored up for me, which the Lord, the righteous judge, will give me on that day – and not to me only, but to all who have loved his appearing.

9 Make every effort to come to me soon. 10 For Demas has abandoned me, because he loved this present age, and has gone to Thessalonica; Crescens has gone to Galatia, Titus to Dalmatia. 11 Only Luke is with me. Pick up Mark and bring him along, for he is useful to me for service. 12 I have sent Tychicus to Ephesus. 13 When you come, bring the cloak that I left with Carpus in Troas,

and the books, especially the parchments. [14] Alexander the metalworker did me much harm – the Lord will repay him according to his works. [15] You too must be on your guard against him, for he strongly opposed our words.

[16] At my first defence no one stood by me, but all abandoned me – may it not be counted against them! [17] But the Lord stood by me and gave me strength, so that through me the proclamation might be fully carried out and all the nations might hear it; and I was rescued from the mouth of the lion. [18] The Lord will rescue me from every evil deed and will save me for his heavenly kingdom. To him be the glory for ever and ever. Amen.

[19] Greet Prisca and Aquila and the household of Onesiphorus. [20] Erastus stayed in Corinth, and I left Trophimus sick in Miletus. [21] Make every effort to come before winter. Eubulus greets you, as do Pudens and Linus and Claudia and all the brothers and sisters.

[22] The Lord be with your spirit. Grace be with you all.